Mindfulness for Exam Season: A Six-Week Classroom Programme for Secondary Students

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Abstract

Exam periods are a predictable source of stress for secondary students. This paper describes a six-week classroom mindfulness programme designed for Form 4 and Form 5 students, delivered in ten-minute blocks at the start of lessons. We outline the session plan, the breathing and attention exercises used, and how teachers can run them without specialist training. In a small pilot with three classes, students reported calmer mornings before papers, better sleep in exam week, and more confidence asking for help. We close with practical guidance for counsellors who want to adapt the programme for their own schools.

Keywords: mindfulness, exam stress, secondary school, classroom programme, wellbeing

1. Introduction

Most students meet exam stress long before they meet a counsellor. The weeks before major papers bring early mornings, crowded revision timetables and a steady stream of comparison with classmates. A little pressure can sharpen focus, but sustained worry tends to crowd out sleep, appetite and the ability to recall what has been learned.

School counsellors are often asked to run one-off talks on stress just before exams. These talks are welcome, yet a single session rarely changes how a student responds when the pressure arrives. Skills such as slowing the breath or noticing a racing thought need repetition, much like any other skill taught in school.

This paper proposes a different approach: short, daily practice built into normal lessons over six weeks. The aim is not to remove stress, which is neither possible nor desirable, but to give students a few reliable tools they have already practised many times before the first paper.

2. Background

Mindfulness, in the sense used here, means paying attention to the present moment on purpose and without harsh judgement. In schools it is usually taught through simple breathing exercises, brief body scans and guided attention to sounds or sensations. None of these require special equipment or a quiet room.

Earlier school programmes have tended to fall into two groups. Some are long courses delivered by trained facilitators, which can be effective but are hard for most schools to staff. Others are single assemblies or apps that students are encouraged to try at home, which are easy to offer but rarely used consistently.

A middle path is to equip ordinary classroom teachers with a short script and a predictable routine. Teachers already manage the start of each lesson; adding a ten-minute practice at that point makes it part of the school day rather than an optional extra.

3. Programme design

The programme runs for six weeks, ending one week before the first major paper. Each week has a theme and two or three short exercises that are repeated across lessons so that students become familiar with them.

Week	Theme	Core exercise
1	Arriving	Three slow breaths before opening books
2	Noticing the body	Ninety-second body scan, seated
3	Thoughts are not facts	Labelling worries as "just a thought"
4	Steady attention	Counting breaths to ten, then restarting
5	Kindness under pressure	Writing one encouraging line to oneself
6	Exam-day routine	Rehearsing the full routine with a timer

Each session follows the same shape: one minute to settle, six minutes of guided practice, and three minutes of quiet reflection or a short written note. Teachers read from a one-page script, which keeps the language consistent across classes and reduces the preparation needed.

Students are told from the first lesson that taking part means sitting quietly; nobody is required to close their eyes or share their experience. This matters for students who find stillness uncomfortable, including some who have experienced trauma.

4. Pilot and findings

The programme was piloted with three Form 5 classes, around one hundred students in total, during the term before their major examinations. Students completed a short wellbeing questionnaire at the start and end of the six weeks, and teachers kept brief notes after each session.

By the final week, most students said they used at least one exercise outside class, most often the three slow breaths before starting a revision session. Many described mornings before papers as calmer than in previous years, and a noticeable number reported falling asleep more easily during exam week.

Teachers found the routine manageable once it became familiar. The most common difficulty was protecting the ten minutes on days with assemblies or tests. Classes that kept the routine consistent reported the clearest benefits.

5. Practical exercises

Three slow breaths. Sit with both feet on the floor. Breathe in through the nose for a count of four, and out through the mouth for a count of six. Repeat three times. Longer out-breaths signal to the body that it is safe to slow down.

The worry label. When a worrying thought appears, silently name it: "I am having the thought that I will fail." Labelling a thought creates a small gap between the student and the worry, which makes it

easier to return to the task.

Ten-breath counting. Count each out-breath from one to ten. If the mind wanders, notice where it went and start again at one. Losing count is not failure; noticing that the mind has wandered is the practice itself.

The exam-day routine. On arrival in the hall: three slow breaths, a quick scan from feet to shoulders, and one kind sentence such as "I have prepared, and I will do what I can." The routine takes under two minutes and can be repeated between sections of a paper.

6. Discussion

The pilot suggests that short, repeated practice can make mindfulness skills available to students when they need them most. Because the programme is delivered by classroom teachers, it can reach whole year groups rather than the few students who seek out counselling.

Counsellors remain essential. Some students will need individual support, and the programme can help identify them: a student who is visibly distressed during a calm exercise may be carrying more than exam stress. Schools should agree in advance how teachers refer such students.

Future work should compare classes with and without the programme, follow students through the full exam period, and test versions in Bahasa Melayu and Mandarin so that every student can practise in the language they think in.

7. Recommendations for schools

Start six weeks before exams, not one. Keep sessions short and at the same point in each lesson. Give teachers a script and permission to keep it simple. Make taking part about sitting quietly, never about performance. Agree a referral path to the counselling team before the programme begins.

8. Sample session script (week 3)

Minute 1 — settle. "Put your pens down and let your hands rest. Feet flat on the floor. If you are comfortable, lower your gaze or close your eyes. If not, look at a spot on the desk."

Minutes 2 to 4 — breathing. "Breathe in through your nose for four... and out through your mouth for six. Again. Notice the air is a little cooler on the way in and warmer on the way out. If your mind wanders, that is normal. Just come back to the breath."

Minutes 5 to 7 — thoughts are not facts. "Think of one worry about the exams. Say it silently, starting with: I am having the thought that... Notice how it feels to put a little space between you and the worry. The thought is there, but it is not the whole truth about you."

Minutes 8 to 10 — reflect. "Open your eyes. In your notebook, write one word for how you feel now, and one thing you will do today to look after yourself while you revise." Teachers collect nothing; the notebook belongs to the student.

9. Adapting the programme

Schools with double periods can run a longer practice once a week and shorter ones on other days. Boarding schools have used the evening prep slot. For students with additional needs, shorter practices of three to five minutes, with visual timers and movement-based exercises such as slow stretching, are often more accessible than seated stillness.

Language matters. Several pilot teachers delivered the script in Bahasa Melayu, and students reported that practising in their first language felt more natural. Translated scripts should be checked by a counsellor so that the meaning of each instruction, especially around worries and feelings, is kept.

Finally, the programme works best when it is not framed as exam preparation alone. Students who learn these skills in Form 4 often return to them in later years, during university applications, first jobs and other stressful transitions.

Appendix A: Student reflection sheet

Week ____ One word for how I feel before practice: _____ One word after: _____

Which exercise helped most this week? _____

When will I use it outside class? _____

One kind sentence I can say to myself on exam day: _____

References

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